Lesson 31: Topic Sentence.

In the last lesson we started to look at paragraph writing. We considered the different parts of a paragraph, and we examined the paragraph My Neighbors.We noted that a good paragraph has three major structural parts: a topic sentence, supporting sentences and a concluding sentence.

In addition to the three structural parts of a paragraph, a good paragraph also has the elements of unity and coherence.

First we will look at the first element UNITY. By unity we mean that only one main idea is stated in the topic sentence and the coherence that follows each and every supporting sentence develops that idea. If you are writing on Dreams and you say in your topic sentence that you are going to discuss two important characteristics of dreams, then discuss only these two characteristics only. Do not discuss any thing else such as what you dreamt the night before.

Or if you were writing on Television, and in your topic sentence you say that you are going to discuss the effects of TV on society, then discuss only that. Do not discuss anything else such as the invention of television. The second element of importance in a paragraph is COHERENCE. By coherence we mean that your paragraph is easy to read and understand because (i) the supporting sentences are in some kind of logical order and (ii) your ideas are connected by the use of appropriate transitional words. We shall look at the topic sentence from the following points

Characteristics

Position

Practice: to recognize topic sentences

Parts of a topic sentences

writing topic sentences

Pract: Writing concluding sentence

Review:

In short: a well written paragraph has 5 elements

(i) a topic sentence
(ii) supporting sentences
(iii) a concluding sentence
(iv) unity
(v) coherence

The Topic sentence. Remember the earlier reading lessons in which we discussed the topic sentence in detail.

You looked at the topic sentence from the readers point of view. Now you will work at it from the writer's point of view. The topic sentence is the most important sentence in a paragraph as it indicates what the paragraph is going to discuss, and for this reason it is a helpful guide, both for reader and writer. Remember that the topic sentence is (a) a complete sentence - it contains a subject, a verb and a complement (which is a word or words used to complete the meaning of a verb).

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(b) A topic sentence contains a topic as well as a controlling idea. i.e. first it names the topic and then it limits the topic to a specific area that is to be discussed in the paragraph.e.g.

-*Driving on the motor way requires skill and agility*

- Platinum, a precious metal is used for two purposes.

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- Platinum, a precious metal is used for two purposes.

Notice that these 2 sentences are general statements they do not contain any specific details.

The topic sentence may appear anywhere in the paragraph. It is usually the first or the last sentence of the paragraph. The topic sentence may also be the first and the last sentence of the paragraph. Let us look at three paragraphs

(I) My study table is well organized. I keep ball point pens and colored pencils in the top right drawer. Writing paper is in the middle right drawer.

(I) My study table is well organized. I keep ball point pens and colored pencils in the top right drawer. Writing paper is in the middle right drawer. The bottom right side has all the other material I might need, from paper clips to staples and tapes. The top of the desk is clear, except for a study lamp and a monthly planner. The left side of the desk has two drawers. The bottom one is a file drawer, where I keep my lecture notes from each class. And in the top drawer? That's where I keep peanuts, raisins, chocolates and chewing gum that I snack on while I study.

The bottom right side has all the other material I might need, from paper clips to staples and tapes. The top of the desk is clear, except for a study lamp and a monthly planner. The left side of the desk has two drawers. The bottom one is a file drawer, where I keep my lecture notes from each class. And in the top drawer? That's where I keep peanuts, raisins, chocolates and chewing gum that I snack on while I study.

Here you noticed the paragraph began with a topic sentence “My study table is well organized”. The first sentence is a general statement. The main idea - that the writer’s desk is well organized - is in the first sentence. The rest of the sentences show us how well organized the desk is.

(2) Do you have problems with sleeping? By following a few single guidelines many sleep problems can be avoided.

First, don’t drink tea or coffee close to bedtime. Next, do not exercise at least three hours before bedtime. Lastly, work out a sleep routine. Try to go to bed at the same time and try to get up at the same time.

Here the first sentence introduces the topic of sleep problems by asking a question. A question can never be a topic sentence. It is not making a statement. The second sentence “By following a few simple guidelines many sleep problems can be avoided” states the author’s main idea about that topic.

Topic sentences may even come later than the second sentence. See if you can find the topic sentence in the following paragraph.

(3) Today world-wide communications are taken for granted. Through telephone, TV and the inter-net, we learn instantly what happens all over the world. In ancient times, however, military leaders relied on a much slower, less technical method of sending important messages - pigeons. Homing pigeons are trained to return home from long distances. The birds were kept in cages at the military camps. When a message had to be sent, it was tied to the bird's leg. The bird was then released and it flew back to its base camp after delivering the message.

At first glance sentence 1 appears to state the main idea as sentence 2 gives examples of the world-wide communication. But it isn't. Sentence 3 which also states a general idea, but points the reader towards another direction (as signaled by the word *however)* Sentences 4, 5, 6 and 7 provide details to support it. It becomes clear that sentences 1 & 2 lead up to the true main idea of the paragraph which is stated in sentence 3. This is clear because sentences 4, 5 and 6 all give information that explains in detail the general statement in sentence 3.

Sometimes a topic sentence may end a paragraph. When this is so the previous sentences build up to the main idea. Here is an example of a paragraph in which the topic sentence comes last.

Probably in the coming decade there will be more use of home computers. People will use them to shop, to cast votes, file taxes, and to take college and university exams. Also, they will be used for playing games. Experts say the work week will be reduced to less than thirty-two hours. Moreover, robots will not only take over many routine service jobs but many dangerous jobs as well. As these forecasts suggest, the coming decade is likely to be a decade of home computers.

Review 1 To find out what you've learned so far answer each of the following questions. Fill in the blank or put a tick mark (□) against the answer you think is correct.

1. The topic sentence of a paragraph states the
   (a) supporting details
   (b) introducing material
   (c) main idea□

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2. To find the topic sentence of a paragraph, look for a general statement. True or False? (T)

3. The supporting details of a paragraph are more general than the main idea. True or False? (F)

4. The topic sentence may appear in a paragraph (a) only once (b) more than once? (b)

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2. To find the topic sentence of a paragraph, look for a general statement. True or False?

3. The supporting details of a paragraph are more general than the main idea. True or False?

4. The topic sentence may appear in a paragraph (a) only once (b) more than once?

5. When the main idea is stated in the last sentence of a paragraph, it is likely to be

(a) a summary

(b) a conclusion

(c) either a or b

Now we shall turn to the parts of a topic sentence. A topic sentence has two essential parts - the topic and the controlling idea. The topic (names) the subject or main idea of the paragraph.

The controlling idea makes a specific comment about the topic, which indicates what the rest of the paragraph will be about. It limits the topic to a specific aspect of the topic that will be discussed in the paragraph. e.g.

- Driving in Lahore requires skill and nerves of steel.
- Living in an English speaking country improves the English of a foreign student.
- Sri Lanka is famous for its tea gardens.
- Television commercials are misleading.

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Writing Topic Sentence

Now you shall have some practice in writing topic sentence. Remember (i) A topic sentence should be neither too general nor too specific (ii) It should not unhide too many unrelated ideas, e.g. Sri Lanka is famous for its temperate climate, its many tea gardens and its ancient temple.

(too many controlling ideas- would require 3 separate paragraphs)

Practice Writing Topic Sentences

Write a topic sentence for each of the following topics include both a topic and controlling idea)

1. The effect of TV on children

Television is seriously affecting children. Their attention span has shortened notably. They are now so used to a TV being on that they have trouble working in quiet classrooms.

Practice Writing Topic Sentences

Write a topic sentence for each of the following topics include both a topic and controlling idea)

1. The effect of TV on children

2. Books on travel / Travel Books
3. Gardens

4. Popular Entertainment (general subject)

5. The Benefits of Foreign Travel

2. Books on travel / Travel Books

Books of travel have always been popular. Even in ancient times traveler's tales were eagerly read. Name a few travelers

- Marco polo
- Ibn-e- Batuta

3. Gardens

A beautiful garden is a constant source of pleasure. (Talk about some pleasure - sit in peace and quiet. Place of retreat, rest.

4. **Popular Entertainment (general subject)**

Popular entertainment such as pop music has undergone great changes.

5. **The Benefits of Foreign Travel.**

Whether travel in foreign lands will benefit the traveler depends entirely on the traveler himself. Opening sentences given - try to carry on from here.

The Concluding Sentence: Now that you have learned to write a good topic sentence for a paragraph, you should also learn how to write a good concluding sentence.A concluding sentence is not essential, but it is often helpful to the reader because it reminds him / her of the important points of the paragraph. A concluding sentence has purposes (I) it signals the end of the paragraph for this you should use words like in conclusion, in summary or finally.

The Concluding Sentence: A concluding sentence has two purposes (i) it signals the end of the paragraph for this you should use words like in conclusion, in summary or finally.

(ii) It gives a final comment on your topic.

The following examples illustrate two different types of concluding sentences

(ii) It gives a final comment on your topic. The following examples illustrate two different types of concluding sentence.The concluding sentence may repeat the main idea of the topic sentence in different words or it may summarize the main points of the paragraph which are not stated in the topic sentence. e.gs.

(I) Synonyms: Most people think of ‘synonyms’ as words ‘having the same meaning’, but it is easy to show that synonyms are always partial never complete.

(I) Most people think of ‘synonyms’ as words ‘having the same meaning’, but it is easy to show that synonyms are always partial, never complete. ‘Tall’ and ‘high’ are usually considered synonyms but while we can have both a tall building and ‘a high building’ we cannot have both ‘a tall boy’ and ‘a high boy’. *Therefore, we should be careful in choosing words because many words that we considered turn out not to be really synonyms* (repeats the main idea of the topic sent)

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(ii) Some people delight in inflicting pain on harmless little creatures. Such as flies, worms and frogs.

They also take pleasure in killing them. This is very cruel of them. They ought not to do so, because it is wrong to cause unnecessary pain to any creature. Besides, from being cruel to little animals, men are often led, to become cruel to their fellow creatures, and they learn to do very cruel deeds. Whenever a man is tempted to hurt or kill any such creature he should pause to think how he would feel if any creature more powerful than he, were to do the same to him.

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Practice 4: Writing Concluding & Sentences

In the following paragraphs underline the topic sentence .

(a)Determine the main idea of each paragraph. (b)Add a good concluding sentence with an end of paragraph signal *(Finally, to sum up, at last, in conclusion)*.

Paragraph 1: The scientist is more interested in doing scientific work than in defining it. He sometimes says that a piece of work or book is unscientific, and what he actually means by that phrase is that it is in exact, that it is badly arranged; that it jumps to conclusions without sufficient evidence, or that the author has allowed his personal prejudices to influence his report. *[by scientific work, then we mean that which is as exact as is possible, orderly in arrangement, and based on sound and sufficient evidence].*

Paragraph 2: The habit of economy can easily be formed if we have a will to save. The first important thing in the formation of this habit, as in the case of many others, is to make a beginning. It does not matter with what sum we begin. We should make use of the first opportunity to make a beginning secondly we should keep this habit alive by consistent effort. All this is possible only by a strong will-power. If once we decide to save, we should start immediately. [*Thus, it is quite easy to form the habit of economy.]*

Paragraph 3: There are numerous everyday words in English that have come from other languages. English speakers relaxing at home, for example may put on *pajama's* which is a Persian word. A sleep in the afternoon is called a 'siesta' a Spanish word. When we wash our hair we *'shampoo'* it - from the South Indian word champi. [so, to conclude we can say that English has enriched its vocabulary by words from many languages of the world.

Writing Practice Home Work.

Choose a topic from the list below and write a paragraph 4-5 sentences in length.

Step I : Begin para w.good topic sentence.

II : Write general supporting sentences that explain or support the topic sentence.

III : Write a good concluding sentence.

Topics

1. Arranged Marriages
2. Population Explosion in Pakistan
3. Computers

Your instructor will give you a time limit, suggested limits:

Writing time = 13 minutes

Checking time = 02 minutes

Total = 15 minutes